

As UNC-Chapel Hill plans to eliminate six area studies centers, students express skepticism regarding the administration's motives

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Editor's note: *The name "Jane" is a pseudonym used at the request of a UNC-Chapel Hill student interviewed for this story who asked to remain anonymous.*

CHAPEL HILL — The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill plans to close six of its area studies centers by the end of the 2026 fiscal year as part of a broader round of budget cuts, a move that has prompted UNC students to question the rationale behind the decision in light of independent financial analyses suggesting the university remains in strong financial condition.

Students who spoke to *The Carrboro Defender* shared the sentiment that the planned closures of the Center for European Studies, African Studies Center, Carolina Asia Center, Center for Middle East and Islamic Studies, Institute for the Study of the Americas and the Center for Slavic, Eurasian and East European Studies could limit study abroad opportunities, reduce funding for international research, weaken cultural and academic communities that connect global diasporas on campus, and undermine UNC's reputation for international scholarship — which could adversely impact the number of international student applications going forward.

The closures come amid ongoing debates in North Carolina and across the United States over diversity initiatives and the funding of cultural and international programs at universities. In recent years, public universities in North Carolina and across the country have faced increasing scrutiny from state legislatures and governing boards over diversity-related initiatives and internationally focused programs.

Eliminating the six area studies centers is projected to save about \$7 million, according to university budget planning discussions. However, an independent financial audit conducted in November 2025 found that UNC remains in strong financial condition, raising questions among some students and campus groups about whether cuts of that scale are really necessary.

In a letter sent to faculty and staff, James W.C. White, Dean of the College of Arts and Sciences, described the closures as "part of a broader package of budget cuts affecting many centers and institutes across

campus.” In his letter, White referenced the roughly \$70 million budget reduction plan announced by UNC leadership in July 2025 in response to potential declines in research funding and broader financial pressures facing higher education.

University leadership plans to integrate many of the centers’ activities into existing Global Studies and Global Programs structures in an effort to preserve certain academic programs, speaker series and travel opportunities, White stated.

In January, the UNC Faculty Council unanimously adopted a resolution that “overwhelmingly” urged University leadership, “not to close, sunset, decommission, or otherwise dismantle the centers and rather to preserve these essential centers,” according to *The Daily Tar Heel*.

Students question the reason for the cuts

An independent audit conducted by Eastern Michigan University accounting professor Howard Bunsis, commissioned by the Workers Union at UNC, the UNC-Chapel Hill chapter of the American Association of University Professors and TransparUNCy, found that UNC currently holds approximately \$10 billion in total assets, \$5.6 billion in cash and \$1.9 billion in unrestricted reserves. The report also found that university cash and investments grew by \$3.5 billion between 2015 and 2025, while institutional debt did not increase.

Bunsis said UNC’s financial indicators suggest the university is in “excellent financial condition,” noting that the university takes in more revenue than it spends and maintains a AAA bond rating — the highest credit rating possible.

Jane, a UNC graduate student involved in Latin American student initiatives, said the independent audit findings raise questions about the University’s motives.

“This leaves students to believe that this decision may be more of a political decision than financial, as they are trying to make it look like,” she said.

UNC students told *The Carrboro Defender* the presence of area studies centers on the historic campus has historically signaled the university’s commitment to global engagement and cultural exchange, but that perception of the University as a welcoming place for international students is rapidly changing among the 46,000 members of the University community.

“Having these centers on campus is the university’s testament to having diversity and inclusion in the first place,” said Erin Kim, a student leader involved in Asian American student organizations.

“So I think even if they are not directly saying it, the closing of the funding and these centers says a lot about where the university is putting their priorities.”

Resources Students Are Losing

Students interviewed by The Carrboro Defender shared the sentiment that the planned closures of area studies centers could significantly impact how they study the world, particularly through study abroad programs.

For example, the Phillips Ambassadors Scholarship, a program operated through the Carolina Asia Center in collaboration with UNC’s Study Abroad Office, has already been paused for the upcoming fall semester. The program historically funded undergraduate study abroad in Asia.

Hailey Desir, a UNC student involved in global studies programs who studied abroad during her first year of college, said programs like this are exactly the kinds of opportunities area studies centers help make possible.

“There are definitely resources for people to study abroad, and I wish everyone could have those same resources and experiences,” Desir said.

Jane said the Institute for the Study of the Americas has long supported Latino students pursuing international research and language study.

“The Institute for the Study of the Americas has been a staple in supporting Latino students with research grants, travel funding and resources for studying languages,” she said. “So I think losing that infrastructure will affect who gets to do their research, who gets to travel and who feels their stories and origins matter at UNC.”

Cultural Spaces and Community Connections

Beyond academic funding, students say the centers have also served as cultural gathering spaces that foster community across campus. For many students, these spaces provide a sense of belonging and connection during a time of growing political polarization on college campuses.

“The Asian American Center definitely did a lot to bring these different Asian diasporas together,” said Kim.

She also emphasized the importance of having physical spaces where students could gather in fellowship.

“It was a place where Asian students could go to find peace and an oasis even during this polarizing time,” Kim said. “Not having access to this physical space and the events anymore, I think is the biggest loss.”

Kim said lectures, cultural celebrations and visiting scholars hosted by the centers also exposed the broader campus community to global perspectives that might otherwise receive less attention in traditional academic departments.

Concerns About UNC’s Global Future

UNC students interviewed by *The Carrboro Defender* shared the concern that the closures may also affect UNC’s reputation as a university known for international engagement.

Jane said there is a risk that reducing institutional support for regional expertise could narrow the scope of global scholarship on campus.

“There’s a risk that international work at UNC will become more insular and less rigorous,” she said.

For students planning careers in diplomacy or international development, the closures have also raised questions about future opportunities. Desir said UNC’s strong global studies programs and study abroad connections were a major reason she chose to attend the university.

“A lot of people I talk to came to UNC because of the global studies program, because of their strong connections to study abroad and because of their support,” Desir said.

Without those resources, she worries UNC could become less appealing to prospective students interested in international careers.

“Could it deter people from coming to UNC? If I’m being completely honest, yes,” she added.

Global studies majors often structure their coursework around specific world regions and the academic centers associated with them.

Desir went on to say that when a UNC student chooses an area of study, they must choose a specific part of the world to focus on, which determines their area study center.

“I am worried for the future of global studies students,” she said. “Will this be a major that still exists in the same way?” Desir asked rhetorically.

Moment of UNCertainty

For many UNC students, the closures of on-campus cultural centers reflect a broader uncertainty surrounding international engagement and global policy careers, and could harm countless students at the oldest public university in America.

Students like Desir believe the loss of these centers could reshape UNC’s identity as a globally engaged university.

“This is a topic that is deserving of funding,” Desir said. “It leaves a lot of uncertainty for the future.”

University officials have promised that more details will be forthcoming later this year regarding how existing programs will be integrated into other departments.

In the meantime, UNC students who spoke to *The Carrboro Defender* all expressed concern about the long-term effects of this unprecedented move by the Board of Trustees to campus culture, including academic opportunities and UNC’s global engagement.

Desir referenced the bigger picture aspect of these cuts to area studies centers — specifically the Trump administration’s assault on education and series of failures in international diplomacy — have already caused some UNC students to reconsider career paths.

“These centers closing down has reaffirmed that this career path, as of now, is not sustainable,” she said.